

Nielsen's 10 Heuristics (Golden Rules)

Jakob Nielsen's **10 general principles for interaction design**. They are called "heuristics" because they are broad rules of thumb and not specific usability guidelines.

He originally developed the heuristics for **heuristic evaluation** in collaboration with Rolf Molich in 1990. Then this set was revised...

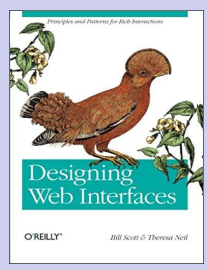


<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/>

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Credits

Examples taken from <http://designingwebinterfaces.com/6-tips-for-a-great-flex-ux-part-5>



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Nielsen's 10 Heuristics

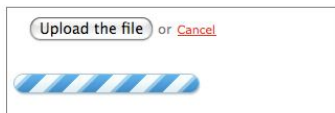
I. Visibility of system status

"What is going on?"
(appropriate feedback within reasonable time)
Communicate clearly with the user!



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Visibility



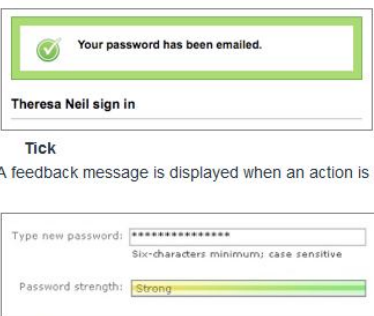
BaseCamp by 37signals
The upload button is enabled, until clicked. Then it is replaced with a progress indicator until the file has finished uploading



Picnik
Progress message and indicator shows while the application loads

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Visibility



Windows Live Account
Password strength is shown as the password is entered

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2. Match between system and real world

"What are you talking about?"
(the system should speak the user's language.. and follow real time conventions)
Make sure users understand what you are talking about!



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Match with real world (metaphor)



iTunes

Organized as a library that contains your media library: music, movies, shows, audiobooks. Beneath the Library is the Store where you can buy more media to put in your Library.

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Nielsen's 10 Heuristics

3. User control and freedom

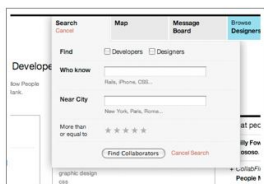
"Oppss.."
(leave unwanted state, undo, redo..)

Always be sure that your system has a simple and efficient emergency exit to "fix" user errors!



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Freedom



CollabFinder

Search is easy to open, enter info, execute or cancel.

	A	B	C	D
1	Item	Quantity	Price	Total
2	Tacos	40	\$5.50	=B2*C2
3				

Pages (Apple's Word Processing Product)
Cell editing shows row and column ids, and the cells used in the equation.
The equation can be saved or canceled.

C	D
Price	Total
\$5.00	=B2*C2

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4. Consistency and standards

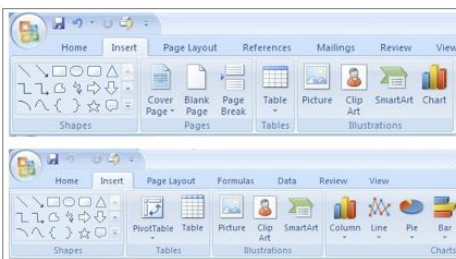
"Oh! I know that!"
(follow platform conventions)

Always make sure that your system has continuity across your platform!



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Consistency



Microsoft Office

Word, Excel, and PowerPoint all use the same style toolbar with the same primary menu options: Home, Insert, Page Layout... Consistency results in efficiency and perceived intuitiveness.

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5. Error prevention

"Glad I didn't do that!"
(make it difficult to make errors..)

Always make sure that your system has efficient error prevention!



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Error prevention



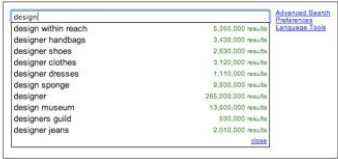
Yammer
Disables the update button after it is clicked, so the person cannot update the post twice by accident



Example from "Web form Design:Filling in the Blanks" by Luke W.
Make the primary action prominent with a larger click area. Cancel and secondary actions are just shown as links

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Error prevention



Google Auto Recommend
The auto recommend feature cuts down on mis-spellings



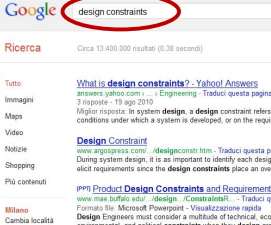
Wikipedia
Auto focus on input prevents a common source of frustration, typing only to realize nothing is displayed because the field did not have focus

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6. Recognition rather than recall

"Wait, what was that already?"
(make objects, actions and options visible and instructions easily retrievable)

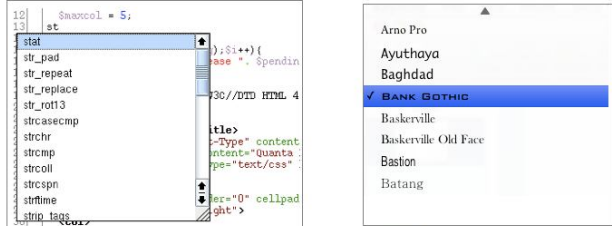


Always make sure that your system prioritizes recognition over recall whenever appropriate!



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Recognition rather than recall



Quanta IDE
Type ahead for coding in a development environment

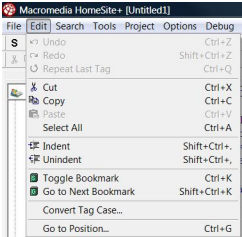
Keynote
Previews the fonts you can pick from, instead of just the font name

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7. Flexibility and efficiency of use

"It doesn't matter if you are an expert or a newbie" (allow tailoring / accelerators..)



Always make sure that your system incorporates accelerators to facilitate expert users without affecting new users!



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8. Aesthetic and minimalist design

"Less is more"
(dialogs should not contain irrelevant information, info units compete for attention)

Always make sure your system is esthetically pleasant and efficiently composed!




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Nielsen's 10 Heuristics

9. Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors

"My bad!"

(error messages in plain language, suggesting the solution)

Always make sure that your system indicates errors and messages in plain language!



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Error handling

Digg
Provides immediate feedback with specific instructions



Humorous 'Page Not Found' Error
Uses a funny image and copy, but provides viable alternatives (article listings and blog link) and a course of action (report it)

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10. Help and documentation

"Now I get it!"

(easy to search; concrete steps..)

Always make sure that your system provides documentation to help the user!



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Help and documentation



GoodBarry
Embedded videos can be used to showcase features as well as get people started using the product



Zenoss
Help tips are displayed on hover, answering the most likely questions about a field or instructions



BaseCamp by 37signals
Help opens a new browser window/tab with a full set of help resources: search, FAQ, video tutorials, customer forums

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